Which approach you choose depends on the details of the library you're working with. Often, stubbing the external service makes sense for the same reason that stubbing ActiveRecord methods does—crafting a call that will reliably return an error is not always possible. If you can, try to stub methods of your adapter rather than methods of the third-party gem; it's generally a good idea to stub only code you control.

Keeping tests consistent with the location of the logic being tested is still a good policy. Use adapter tests to ensure that the adapter behaves gracefully when it gets weird responses from the server. (Normally, server or gem exceptions shouldn't leak out of the adapter.) Use unit tests to make sure that the clients are able to handle whatever the adapter does in response to unexpected input.

Prescription 39 Test the error code based on which object in the system needs to respond to the error.

Smoke Tests and VCR Options

So far you've used VCR to record an interaction once and preserve it for all time. VCR provides other options. These options are passed as key/value arguments to `VCR.use_cassette(re_record_interval: 7.days)` or, if you're using RSpec metadata, as the value part of the metadata, as in `vcr: {re_record_interval: 7.days}`.

That `re_record_interval` I just used as an example allows you to use the same VCR test as both an integration and a smoke test. The `re_record_interval` is an amount of time. If the requests on the associated cassette are older than the interval, then VCR will attempt to reconnect to the HTTP server and re-record the cassette. If the server is unavailable, VCR will just use the existing cassette.

This allows you to protect your application against API changes in the server. If the server API changes, eventually your VCR cassette will pick up the change and your test will fail. This can be a useful feature. It can also be a little on the opaque side when a test randomly fails, but it's better to have an opaque failure in testing than to have one in production.

VCR lets you set different record modes with the `:record` option. The default, which you've been using so far, is `:once`, which records new interactions if they don't exist but raises an error for new interactions if the cassette already exists.

The table on page 300 lists all the VCR recording options.